group of six Arab terrorists were holding 26 people hostage. Meticulously prepared and executed, the assault took 11 minutes to achieve its objective. Five of the terrorists were shot dead and the other was arrested. Two hostages had also died at the hands of the terrorists. Shown live on television, this operation made the SAS famous throughout the world.

Part of the new SAS image created by the Iranian Embassy siege was of cold-blooded killers, for at least some of the terrorists had been shot dead after ceasing resistance. Criticism of the SAS's allegedly excessive ruthlessness surfaced during the long struggle against IRA terrorism in the 1980s. SAS units were deployed in an undercover role in Northern Ireland with great success, until accusations of a shoot-to-kill policy led to their withdrawal from the province. In a highly publicized operation, in Gibraltar in March 1988, the SAS shot three IRA bombers dead under controversial circumstances. The ruthlessness of the SAS men was praised in some quarters and criticized in others, but no one suggested they had gone beyond their orders.



Iranian Embassy siege
An SAS soldier becomes entangled in his rope during the Iranian Embassy siege in 1980. The team rappelled from the roof to a first floor balcony.

SPECIALIST INFANTRY

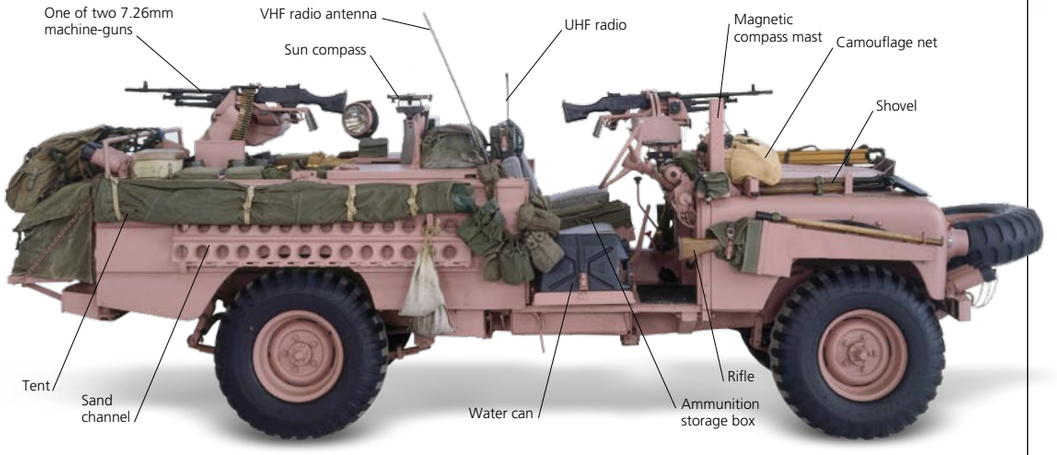
Despite the publicity attracted by Counter Revolutionary Warfare, the primary role of the SAS has remained as specialist light infantry. How their special skills could be used in a conventional war was demonstrated when Britain went to war with Argentina over possession of the Falkland Islands in 1982.

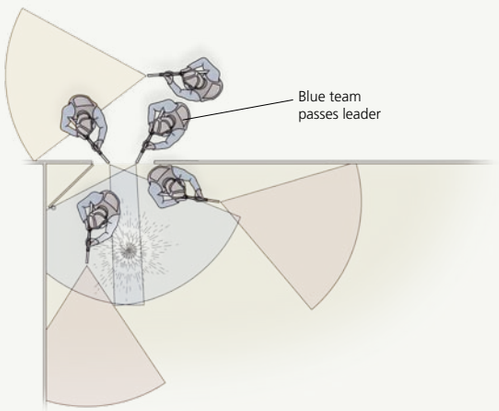
As a British Task Force headed for the islands, which had been occupied by Argentinian troops, four-man SAS patrols were inserted into the islands by helicopter to establish covert observation posts. Surviving for weeks in hiding amid harsh terrain and appalling weather conditions, they transmitted details of the deployment of Argentine forces. After one patrol identified an airstrip as a target for a raid, more than 50 SAS men were flown in by helicopter, destroying 11 Argentinian aircraft on the ground and escaping with only minor casualties. Save for the use of helicopters, this was just the sort of operation that the SAS had carried out against Rommel's forces in the Western Desert during World War II. SAS units were involved in similar behind-the-lines operations in the 1991 Gulf War. Dropped into Iraq by helicopter or driving across the desert border in Land Rovers or on motorbikes, they hunted down and destroyed Scud missile launchers and disrupted enemy communications.

MOVING ON

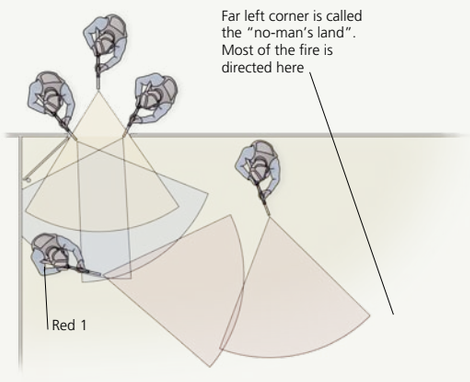
NCOs and troopers generally only leave the SAS when it is time to return to civilian life. A certain percentage find occupations that employ the skills they have learned, such as being bodyguards, carrying out industrial espionage, or even being mercenaries. Officers only join the SAS on secondment from their parent regiments and often return to more conventional duties after a time. Some have risen to very senior positions in the British Army, reflecting the high esteem in which the SAS is held.

SAS "Pink Panther"
Named after its desert camouflage, this modified Land Rover, in use from the 1960s to the 1980s, had fuel tanks that gave it a range of 2,400km (1,500 miles).

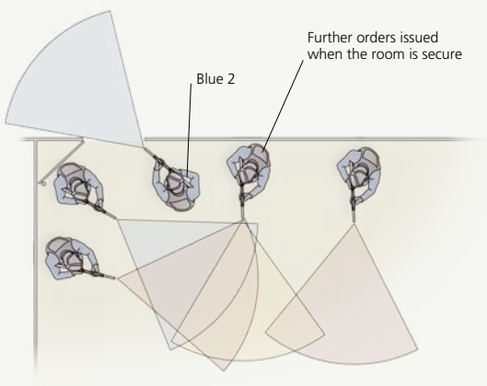




The fatal funnel
Red 1 enters first and covers the right half of the room, then Red 2 follows, covering the left. Blue 1 and Blue 2 prepare to enter while the leader covers the hallway.



Clearing the room
As Red 1 moves to the far right corner, pointing his weapon at the opposite corner, Red 2 moves to the near left corner, pointing his weapon at the opposite wall.



Securing the room
Red 2 clears the near left corner while Red 1 covers the far left. Blue 1 enters and holds the near right corner, followed by Blue 2 who covers the door. Finally the leader enters.